

Auxiliary letters

An auxiliary letter is a type of silent letter that can change the pronunciation of a word. For example, if the letter *a* in *coat* is removed, this would spell another word, *cot*, which sounds different and has a different meaning from *coat*.

kite → Here, the silent *e* is an auxiliary letter because, if it is removed, the sound changes. It would also be confused with the existing word *kit*.

Letter	When it can be silent	Examples
a	after o	boat, coat, goat
b	after m	climb, comb, tomb
c	before t	indict
d	before g	badge, dodge, judge
e	at the end of a word	hope, kite, site
g	after i and before n after i and before m	benign, design, sign paradigm
h	after c	ache
i	only in one word	business
l	before k before m	folk, talk, walk calm, palm
s	after i	aisle, island
w	before h	who, whom, whose

Regional variations

One aspect that varies from one accent to the next is the silencing and sounding of particular letters. The English language includes a range of regional accents, each with its own peculiarities. Even so, two people raised in the same region might pronounce the same word differently.

better → Some speakers don't pronounce the final *r* in this word.

Letter	When it can be either silent or heard	Examples
h	before e after w	herb which, whip, whiskey
r	after a vowel	born, car, star
t	before or after another consonant	often, fasten, tsunami

About **60 percent** of English words contain a **silent letter**.

👍

- Some words that contain silent letters stem from **other languages**. The words *knife*, *knock* and *know*, which all have a **silent k**, are **Old Norse** words. The words *bright*, *daughter* and *night*, which all contain the **silent gh**, are **Anglo-Saxon** words.